exploited the sentiments against the military dictatorship to rally the masses. For the next one week, Patwardhan and his team of seasoned spies focused on the second stage of the operation by gathering intelligence on Ershad's moves against the agitation. Foreknowledge of the government's military actions helped them further calibrate the plan. For their parts, Ismail and Amir developed tried and tested contacts in various organisations to garner support for a public movement. The major effort, Patwardhan recalled, was to ensure that Indian footprints on any such agitation were not visible.

'It was made clear to us by the top bosses that we could not afford to leave footprints of Indian intervention in Bangladesh's domestic affairs. We were on our own. Very few at the top were aware of the work [that] a small team of Indian spies were doing in hostile territory/ Patwardhan said.

Nevertheless, Patwardhan urged his colleagues to reassure the leaders of the movement and the informers that unflinching support from India would continue till Ershad was thrown out. The team handling Operation Farewell now needed to engineer a sustained and high-pressure movement for the final stage of the plan. By the first week of November 1990, the team had destroyed every single page of handwritten notes to ensure that India could never be tied to a people's uprising in case the plan went wrong. By this time, Ershad was helpless. He knew that absolute support from the military was impossible and that pinning any hopes on the USA and Pakistan could only be futile. Rakesh Dixit briefed Ismail and Amir that the battle had now moved from the street to the mind and Ershad could not keep his hold on the government for much longer. The only questions left were when he would go and how.